KNOWLEDGE ASSET | KA-003

Is a Well Casing 6.5 Inches Above Ground Acceptable in Nova Scotia?

A field-based explanation of the provincial minimum and the other wellhead conditions that still matter.

Version	1.0	**Status**	Published
Category	Private Well Inspection	**Location**	Nova Scotia
Based on	An anonymized field inspection	**Audience**	Home buyers and owners
Primary question	Is 6.5 in. above grade acceptable?	**Updated**	July 23, 2026
Keywords	well casing height; wellhead; surface drainage	**Asset ID**	KA-003

1. Customer Question

A drilled-well casing was measured at approximately 6.5 inches above the surrounding ground. Is that height acceptable under Nova Scotia requirements, and does it mean the wellhead is adequately protected?

2. Short Answer

Yes - 6.5 inches is slightly above Nova Scotia's minimum of 152 mm, which is approximately 6 inches. However, casing height is only one part of a sanitary wellhead assessment. Drainage, cap condition, sealing, grading and changes to the surrounding ground level must also be evaluated.

3. Why This Matters

The top of a private well is a critical barrier between groundwater and surface contamination. A casing that is too low, damaged, poorly capped or surrounded by ground that directs runoff toward the well can increase the opportunity for surface water, sediment, insects or other contaminants to reach the well system.

A buyer can therefore misunderstand the condition in either direction: a casing near 6 inches is not automatically deficient, but meeting the minimum height does not automatically prove that the wellhead is safe.

4. Technical Background

Provincial minimum

Nova Scotia's Well Construction Regulations require the casing of a drilled well to extend at least 152 mm above the ground surface when the well is completed. The same 152 mm minimum is specified for dug-well casing.

Height is measured relative to grade

The reference point is the ground surface around the well. Later landscaping, added soil, mulch, paving or settlement can change the effective exposed height even when the steel casing itself has not changed.

Other protective features

The regulations also address casing sealing and prevention of surface-water entry through the annular space. Provincial homeowner guidance recommends sloping the area around the well so runoff drains away and maintaining a suitable, sealed and vermin-resistant cap.

5. Real Field Observation

During an anonymized private-well inspection in Nova Scotia, the exposed drilled-well casing was measured at approximately 6.5 inches above the surrounding ground. The measurement was documented as part of the well inspection rather than judged against an assumed 12-inch requirement.

After checking the current provincial regulation, the measured height was found to be slightly above the 152 mm minimum. The correct interpretation was therefore not “casing too low,” but “minimum height appears satisfied; assess the remaining wellhead conditions separately.”

6. Measurements

Parameter	Observed / Required	Interpretation
Observed exposed casing height	Approx. 6.5 in.	Field measurement
Provincial minimum	152 mm / approx. 6 in.	Minimum appears satisfied
Margin above minimum	Approx. 0.5 in.	Small margin; future grade changes matter

Parameter	Observed / Required	Interpretation
Drainage, cap and sealing	Separate observations	Must not be inferred from height alone

7. Engineering Interpretation

A measured height of 6.5 inches provides only a modest margin above the provincial minimum. It should not be reported as non-compliant solely because it is below 12 inches. At the same time, the small margin means that landscaping changes or soil accumulation could reduce the exposed height.

The wellhead should be interpreted as a system. Its resistance to surface contamination depends on the interaction of casing height, cap integrity, electrical-cable penetrations, annular sealing, surrounding slope and the path taken by rainwater or snowmelt.

A home inspection or well inspection is visual and non-destructive. It can identify observed conditions and recommend qualified follow-up, but it generally cannot verify concealed grout or underground annular seals.

8. Lessons Learned

- Nova Scotia's stated minimum casing height is 152 mm, approximately 6 inches.
- A 6.5-inch measurement is not automatically a defect.
- A small margin above minimum can be affected by later landscaping or accumulated soil.
- Casing height does not replace inspection of the cap, sealing and surface drainage.
- Regulatory conclusions should be checked against the current provincial text, not a remembered rule from another jurisdiction.

9. Recommendations

- Measure exposed casing height from the surrounding ground surface and photograph the reference point.
- Confirm that the ground directs runoff away from the well rather than toward it.
- Inspect the cap for secure attachment, gasket condition, openings, damage and evidence of insect or vermin entry.
- Avoid adding soil, mulch or landscaping materials that reduce the exposed casing height.
- Test private-well water regularly and after flooding, well repairs or suspected surface-water entry.
- Use a certified well contractor for repair or modification of the well.

10. Frequently Asked Questions

Is 12 inches required in Nova Scotia?

The current provincial Well Construction Regulations specify at least 152 mm, approximately 6 inches, above the ground surface when the well is completed. A 12-inch rule should not be applied unless another applicable requirement or site-specific condition establishes it.

Does 6.5 inches prove that the well is safe?

No. It addresses one visible dimension. Cap integrity, sealing, drainage, location and water-test results remain important.

Can landscaping create a problem later?

Yes. Added soil, mulch, pavement or changes in grading can reduce exposed casing height or direct runoff toward the well.

Can a home inspector certify hidden well construction?

Normally no. A visual inspection can document accessible conditions. Concealed casing length, grout and underground seals may require records or evaluation by a certified well contractor.

Should water be tested if the casing height meets the minimum?

Yes. Construction observations do not replace water-quality testing. Nova Scotia states that private-well owners are responsible for regular testing.

11. Related Knowledge Assets

- KA-001 - Why a Good Flow Rate Does Not Always Mean a Good Well
- KA-002 - Understanding a Total Coliform Positive and E. coli Negative Result
- Future asset - How Surface Drainage Can Affect a Private Well

12. Revision History

Version	Date	Changes
1.0	July 23, 2026	Initial publication based on an anonymized field observation and current Nova Scotia requirements.

13. References

- Nova Scotia. Well Construction Regulations, N.S. Reg. 58/95, Section 21(2)(b) and Section 26(2)(b). Current online consolidation accessed July 23, 2026. https://novascotia.ca/just/regulations/regs/envwellc.htm
- Nova Scotia Environment. Private Wells - Drinking Water. Accessed July 23, 2026. https://novascotia.ca/nse/water/privatewells.asp
- Nova Scotia Environment. A Guide for Private Well Owners. Guidance on well protection, drainage and regular water testing. https://novascotia.ca/nse/water/docs/wellwaterbookletEnglish.pdf

Professional note

This Knowledge Asset provides general educational information based on an anonymized field observation. It is not a certification of any specific well and does not replace site-specific evaluation, laboratory testing or work by a certified well contractor.